

THREAT INTELLIGENCE CAPSTONE

Threat Actor Profiling & Risk Assessment.

for Novacore Financial Services

ASSUMED REGION

Germany / European Union

SELECTED THREAT GROUP

Evil Corp (Indrik Spider / UNC2165)

ANALYST

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COHORT

10Alytics Cybersecurity Cohort C26-04

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SECTION 1

Executive Summary

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Financially Motivated
Groups Assessed

Evil Corp

Selected for
Deep-Dive Analysis

Medium-High

Overall Risk Rating
to Novacore

Novacore Financial Services is a fintech company providing payment processing and digital wallet services to SMB clients, assumed to operate in Germany/EU. Because it sits directly in the payment flow and holds concentrated transaction data, it is an attractive target for financially motivated cybercrime independent of its size.

Evil Corp (Indrik Spider) was selected based on its decade-long history of targeting European banks through phishing-delivered credential theft, and its pivot into ransomware and extortion, a close match to Novacore's payment and wallet exposure.

Top priority: phishing-resistant MFA and email security controls, since nearly every documented Evil Corp intrusion starts with a social-engineering foothold, not a technical exploit.

Novacore Threat Profile

BUSINESS PROFILE

Industry	Fintech / Digital Payments
Region	Germany / European Union
Services	Payment processing, digital wallets, SMB onboarding
Sensitive Data	Customer, transaction, and onboarding (KYC) records

EXPOSED THREAT CATEGORIES

- Phishing / spearphishing of employees and SMB clients
- Credential theft targeting wallet and admin logins
- Malicious attachments disguised as invoices
- Ransomware: service disruption pressure to pay
- Payment fraud and fraudulent merchant onboarding
- Business email compromise (BEC)
- Data theft / extortion of transaction records

Regional context: GDPR/PSD2/DORA compliance pressure makes EU fintechs attractive ransomware targets, and Lazarus Group has directly documented targeting of Germany.

SECTION 3

Intelligence Requirements

The questions this research was designed to answer, before selecting and profiling threat groups:

- 1 Which financially motivated threat groups have a track record of targeting payment processors, digital wallets, or fintechs specifically, not only large traditional banks?
- 2 Which of these groups have documented activity in Germany or the wider EU, or have targeted organizations with a similar SMB-facing business model?
- 3 Which groups favor phishing, credential theft, or malware delivery as an initial access method, given that this is Novacore's most exposed surface?
- 4 Which groups have a history of ransomware or extortion against financial-sector targets, and how does that map to Novacore's exposure to downtime and disclosure costs?
- 5 Of the candidates identified, which one presents the closest match to Novacore's profile (fintech, EU region, SMB clients, payments and wallets)?
- 6 Based on that group's known TTPs, what preventive, detection, and response controls should Novacore prioritize first?

SECTION 4

Five Threat Groups Researched

Medium fit

FIN7

Retail/hospitality-rooted; spear-phishing + ransomware big-game hunting since 2020.

Medium fit

Lazarus Group

DPRK state-directed; banks, exchanges, DeFi; documented German targeting.

High fit

Scattered Spider

Help-desk impersonation, MFA bypass; expanding into financial services.

High fit

Evil Corp

European banking-credential theft via phishing; now ransomware/extortion.

High fit

TA505 / Clop

Sustained financial-sector focus; mass malware distribution + data extortion.

All five profiled using MITRE ATT&CK group pages and current vendor / government reporting.

Threat Group Comparison

Group	EU Region	Phishing	Malware	Ransomware	Relevance
FIN7	Low-Med	Yes	Yes	Yes	Medium
Lazarus Group	Medium	Yes	Yes	No	Medium
Scattered Spider	Medium	Yes	Yes	Yes	High
Evil Corp	High	Yes	Yes	Yes	High
TA505 / Clop	Med-High	Yes	Yes	Yes	High

Lazarus Group and FIN7 stay in the report as strong secondary profiles, aimed slightly off-center from Novacore's SMB payments/wallet profile.

TOP 3 FOR NOVACORE

- 1. Evil Corp: closest historical match on European banking-credential theft plus ransomware.
- 2. Scattered Spider: most active model; help-desk social engineering fits a support-heavy fintech.
- 3. TA505 / Clop: sustained financial-sector focus and matching data-extortion impact.

Evil Corp (Indrik Spider / UNC2165)

Russia-based cybercriminal group active since 2014. Built its reputation with the Dridex banking trojan, harvesting credentials from hundreds of banks in 40+ countries (over \$100M stolen). After 2019 US sanctions, pivoted through BitPaymer, WastedLocker, and Hades ransomware, and since ~2022 has operated as a LockBit RaaS affiliate to obscure attribution.

WHY SELECTED FOR NOVACORE

- Sustained history of targeting financial organizations
- Direct, explicit targeting of Western Europe
- Core initial access = phishing, matching Novacore's exposure
- Adapts tooling (LockBit affiliation) to survive sanctions

MOST RELEVANT TTPs

Initial Access

Phishing / SocGhosh drive-by downloads

Credential Access

Banking credential harvesting (Dridex-style)

Defense Evasion

Frequent ransomware rebranding to evade detection

Impact

Data Encrypted for Impact: ransomware/extortion

Famous Attack: Garmin / WastedLocker

DATE	MALWARE	REPORTED RANSOM	OUTAGE
July 2020	WastedLocker ransomware	\$10 million (via intermediary)	Multiple days across services

Garmin's fitness-tracker services, customer support, and commercial aviation tools (flight-plan filing, account sync) were knocked offline after Evil Corp-linked WastedLocker encrypted files across its infrastructure. Because Evil Corp was under US Treasury sanctions, any ransom payment risked violating sanctions law, so Garmin reportedly paid via a third-party intermediary.

WHY IT MATTERS TO NOVACORE

An equivalent outage at Novacore would not just cost revenue during downtime; it would directly interrupt SMB clients' ability to get paid, likely trigger GDPR/DORA disclosure obligations, and raise the same illegal-payment complication Garmin faced if a sanctioned actor were behind it.

Recent Activity (2024–2026)

In October 2024, a UK NCA-led coalition indicted a senior Evil Corp / LockBit affiliate and sanctioned other members, including a former FSB officer tied to the group's leadership. CrowdStrike reporting shows the group gaining access through its SocGholish (Fake Browser Update) distribution service and deploying LockBit ransomware, activity that independent trackers report continuing into 2025-2026, alongside links to the Raspberry Robin malware family.

Area	Famous Attack (2020)	Recent Activity (2024-2026)
Initial Access	Suspected social engineering / drive-by	SocGholish drive-by at scale
Malware	WastedLocker (exclusive, attributable)	LockBit (shared RaaS, harder to attribute)
Impact	Multi-day outage, large single ransom	Ongoing, distributed intrusions

Core tradecraft (phishing/drive-by → ransomware) has stayed consistent since 2020; the tooling layer evolves specifically to complicate sanctions enforcement and attribution.

Risk Assessment for Novacore

OVERALL RISK RATING

Medium–High

Driven primarily by phishing-based credential theft and the ransomware/ extortion impact that would follow a successful intrusion.

LIKELIHOOD

Evil Corp has a sustained, explicit history of targeting Western European financial institutions and remains active as of 2026 despite sanctions. Novacore's SMB payment/wallet services present a plausible, if smaller, target.

IMPACT

Fraudulent transfers, ransomware disruption of payment processing, GDPR/DORA regulatory exposure, and reputational damage to a trust-dependent payment intermediary.

MOST EXPOSED BUSINESS AREAS

- Employees with email access (phishing / SocGhoshish surface)
- Digital wallet and payment-processing systems
- Customer support / help-desk credential resets
- Business onboarding (KYC) data stores
- Identity and access management for admin accounts

Recommendations & Conclusion

PREVENTIVE

- Phishing-resistant MFA (FIDO2) on all accounts
- Stronger email filtering vs. phishing & SocGhosh
- Regular payment-themed phishing training
- Least-privilege on wallet/payment systems

DETECTION

- Monitor failed logins & MFA challenges
- Watch for Cobalt Strike beacon patterns
- Flag drive-by / fake-update activity
- Track known Evil Corp IOCs via threat intel

RESPONSE

- Quarantine suspicious emails, block IOCs
- Isolate endpoints on ransomware precursors
- Reset credentials on suspected compromise
- Escalate to SOC, legal, and regulators as required

Evil Corp is the threat group most relevant to Novacore. Its Garmin case and continued 2024–2026 activity both show a group that adapts its tooling to survive sanctions while keeping its phishing-driven entry point consistent. Closing that entry point is Novacore's single highest-value defensive priority.